PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #54 · PTSD

“I’m permanently damaged by what happened, and I will never be myself again.”

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Where it often comes from

Harm can leave real marks: fear, numbness, shame, a life that does not feel like the one you had. Those marks matter. The lie is the word “permanently,” and the claim that you will never be yourself again. Healing is often slow and incomplete in the way people wish, and it is not the same as being finished as a person. You do not have to describe what happened in order to question this sentence. A counselor can walk with you. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

God heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds. He sends good news and liberty to the captive, not a label of permanent ruin. His grace is sufficient, and His power is made perfect in weakness. Anyone in Christ is a new creation. He is near the brokenhearted. These promises do not mean you should feel like your old self by Friday. They mean “never” and “permanently” are bigger than the evidence, and bigger than the gospel.

> *“He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds”* (Psalm 147:3).

Also see

> “The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners” (Isaiah 61:1).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

Common self-statements

- I am ruined.
- The real me is gone.
- People who heal were not hurt like I was.
- If I am not better yet, I never will be.
- I should not hope. It will only hurt.
- God cannot do anything with someone this damaged.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Deciding that because you are not healed yet, you never will be.
- Labeling: Calling your whole self ruined because you carry wounds.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If you are not your old self, you are permanently destroyed.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring any strength, love, or small change that is still yours.

Challenging questions

- What is still true about me that this sentence erases?
- Am I asking healing to be finished before I will believe it can happen?
- Would I tell a wounded friend they are permanently ruined?
- What small sign of life have I noticed, even if I do not trust it yet?
- What does God do with the brokenhearted?
- What pace has my counselor said is honest for me?

Truth summary

> I was hurt, and I am not permanently ruined. God is healing what I cannot rush, and I can still be myself in His hands.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

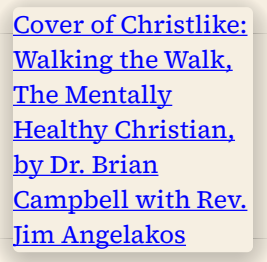
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Sorrow
- Depression, Symptoms of
- Hopeless
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Suffering
- Self-Esteem, Low

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God makes things new. Damage is not His last word about you.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God works with wounded people. He does not discard them.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
What God says about you is not "ruined forever."

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
You belong to Christ. What happened does not get to name you.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm permanently damaged by what happened, and I will never be myself again."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm permanently damaged by what happened, and I will never be myself again." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is still true about me that this sentence erases?
- ☐ Am I asking healing to be finished before I will believe it can happen?
- ☐ Would I tell a wounded friend they are permanently ruined?
- ☐ What small sign of life have I noticed, even if I do not trust it yet?
- ☐ What does God do with the brokenhearted?
- ☐ What pace has my counselor said is honest for me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I was hurt, and I am not permanently ruined. God is healing what I cannot rush, and I can still be myself in His hands.
- ☐ A wound is not a finished identity.
- ☐ I may not feel like myself yet, and that is not the same as never.
- ☐ God binds up the brokenhearted.
- ☐ Grace is enough in weakness.
- ☐ I can heal slowly, with a counselor, without having to be who I was.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 147:3
  "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."
- ☐ Isaiah 61:1
  "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners."

☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9

"But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you felt permanently ruined: Each day, write down one moment when being yourself again felt impossible. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 147:3 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God binds up the brokenhearted. I am wounded, and I am not finished.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Name what remains. Write three things that are still you: a value, a love, a skill. No details of the harm.
- [ ] Talk with your counselor about the word "permanently." Ask what slow healing has looked like for others. Stop if you need to.
- [ ] Do one ordinary thing that is yours this week, something you liked before or still like a little.
- [ ] If "never" includes wanting to die, call or text 988, or tell your counselor or someone near you today.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm permanently damaged by what happened, and I will never be myself again.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I was still myself
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm permanently damaged by what happened, and I will never be myself again~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I feel ruined and afraid I will never be myself. Bind up what is broken. Do not let this wound be my name. Give me patience, and a counselor to walk with me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.